INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #54 · FORGIVING OTHERS

"They don't deserve to be forgiven."

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Where it often comes from

When harm is serious, it is natural to feel that the person has forfeited forgiveness, especially if they have shown no remorse. Our sense of justice is not wrong. But if forgiveness depends on deserving, it never comes, and we remain tied to the person by anger.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, "Be kind and tenderhearted to one another, forgiving each other just as in Christ God forgave you." "God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us." Micah says, "Who is a God like You, who pardons iniquity… because He delights in loving devotion?" Peter asked how often to forgive, and Jesus answered, "not just seven times, but seventy-seven times!" None of us deserved forgiveness. They may not deserve it, and neither did we. Forgiving does not mean they are innocent. It means we release them to God, who judges justly.

> *"Be kind and tenderhearted to one another, forgiving each other just as in Christ God forgave you"* (Ephesians 4:32).

Also see

> "But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us" (Romans 5:8).

> "Who is a God like You, who pardons iniquity and passes over the transgression of the remnant of His inheritance—who does not retain His anger forever, because He delights in loving devotion? He will again have compassion on us; He will vanquish our iniquities. You will cast out all our sins into the depths of the sea" (Micah 7:18–19).

> "Then Peter came to Jesus and asked, 'Lord, how many times shall I forgive my brother who sins against me? Up to seven times?' Jesus answered, 'I tell you, not just seven times, but seventy-seven times!'" (Matthew 18:21–22).

> "As far as the east is from the west, so far has He removed our transgressions from us" (Psalm 103:12).

Common self-statements

- What they did is unforgivable.
- They have not earned it.
- They are not sorry.
- They should suffer for what they did.
- Forgiving would be unfair.
- They do not deserve peace.

Common logical errors

- Should statements: Insisting that they must pay before I forgive.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing they either deserve forgiveness or not.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling righteous anger and concluding I should hold it.
- Magical thinking: Believing that holding resentment punishes them.

Challenging questions

- What do I think they deserve, and who is responsible for that?

- Does holding on to resentment hurt them or me?
- What did I deserve when Christ forgave me?
- What would it mean to hand them over to God?
- What does justice look like, and who delivers it?
- What would I gain by releasing it?

Truth summary

> They may not deserve forgiveness, and neither did I. Forgiving them does not make them innocent. It releases them to God's justice and frees me from the weight of resentment.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Forgiveness
- Forgive
- Vengeance
- Mercy
- Hatred

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Anger
- Communication

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

This Is Amazing Grace — Phil Wickham
Christ bears the burden of rescue rather than demanding self-salvation.

Forgiveness — Matthew West
Ask God for help releasing resentment while working through real hurt.

Amazing Grace My Chains Are Gone — Chris Tomlin
Salvation and freedom come through grace rather than earning acceptance.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "They don't deserve to be forgiven"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"They don't deserve to be forgiven." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What do I think they deserve?
- ☐ What did I deserve?
- ☐ Who judges?
- ☐ What does holding on cost?
- ☐ What would releasing give me?
- ☐ What support do I need?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Forgiveness is a gift, not a wage.
- ☐ Christ forgave me while I was a sinner.
- ☐ God pardons iniquity.
- ☐ Justice belongs to God.
- ☐ Resentment does not punish them.
- ☐ Forgiving frees me.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Ephesians 4:32
  "Be kind and tenderhearted to one another, forgiving each other just as in Christ God forgave you."
- ☐ Romans 5:8
  "But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us."
- ☐ Micah 7:18–19
  "Who is a God like You, who pardons iniquity and passes over the transgression of the remnant of His inheritance— who does not retain His anger forever, because He delights in loving devotion? He will again have compassion on us; He will vanquish our iniquities. You will cast out all our sins into the depths of the sea."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Gift, not wage: Each week, note one way holding on cost you and one way you released.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Ephesians 4:32 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I forgive as God forgave me, though I did not deserve it either.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Mercy" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Write what they owe. Write the debt you feel is owed.
- [ ] Compare to your forgiveness. Write how Christ treated your debt.
- [ ] Release the debt in prayer. Tell God you entrust justice to Him.
- [ ] Seek accountability where appropriate. If crimes occurred, involve authorities and safe support.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "They don't deserve to be forgiven": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Debt released
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~They don't deserve to be forgiven.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, they do not deserve it, and neither did I. Thank You for forgiving me. Help me release this debt to You, trusting You to judge justly. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.